

Game Design Document Version 0.01

Working Title: Voxelation

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Elevator Pitch

Sci-fi 3rd Person Tactical Role Playing Game (TRPG) that uses a deck builder combat system with a cinematic combo system.

Vision

Sleek 3rd Person TRPG that is unique by using a deck builder system for combat encounters where the player can choose a series of attacks per turn that utilises a Cinematic Action (CA) system to link various attacks to add flair and style to improve player engagement.

Influences

The core influences for Voxelation are Persona and Fire Emblem for the TRPG aspects as well as Slay the Spire and Marvel's Midnight Suns for the Deck building aspects.

Theme / Setting / Genre / Art Style

Theme

The theme or heart of the game is just to be “Jovial and Entertaining”

Setting

The main locale will be a corporate city where the player can access various locations for services like shops and to access mission areas such as corporate offices and warehouses.

Genre

The core genre is TRPG with a secondary genre of deck builder.

Art Style

The art style will be Neon-Futuristic and be stylised to allow for more colourful and vibrant characters and world without forsaking character detail.

Concept Art Mock-Ups

The Nexus

The Hideout

Floor Clusters

Player Characters

Enemy Characters

Target Platform & Demographic

Target Platform

PC.

Target Demographic

The primary target demographic we are aiming for are fans of TRPG's with a secondary audience being fans of Deck Builders. We are targeting a mature audience.

What Sets This Game Apart

The primary aspect that makes this game unique is the blending of the mechanics of a TRPG with the gameplay loop of a deck builder, creating a new way to engage and explore a new world.

This means the core gameplay will play like a TRPG (levelling, exploration, combat structure, etc.) with the combat loop of a deck builder (acquiring new cards, cultivating a deck, spending resources to play cards to inflict damage, apply buffs/debuffs, etc.)

The second aspect that sets this game apart is the CA system. This is unique as it adds an extra level of style and flair by allowing the player to perform combos that have a level of cinematic quality to them during combat encounters.

Game Narrative

The Player is the leader of a small team of operatives. This team is deployed by *company A* on missions of slim success due to their unorthodox approach. This has made them one of the companies best assets albeit begrudgingly until they are suddenly black listed. Using their uncommon and unpredictable approach to problems, they will work together to find the truth and clear their names.

Characters

The Player

Company A

Gameplay Mechanics

Cards (Chips)

The player will be able to acquire cards (chips) that they can compile into decks (chipsets). Chips will be used to perform all types of actions during combat such as attacking, moving, applying effects, etc. generic use chips will be randomly acquired after combat ends through either loot or other rewards. Special chips will be able to be acquired through merchants, completing quests and acquiring skills from levelling.

Generic use chips are played to perform generic actions, such as moving, basic attacks, healing, etc. Special chips are more unique chips that can access the combo system, provide additional effects such as hot-fixes or bugs, or are just generally more powerful attacks.

Chips are split amongst 3 categories; Attack, Bug and Hot-fix

Attack chips are how characters defeat each other in combat. When an attack chip is engaged, it will inflict damage to the target based on the chip played as well as the resistances and defences of the target.

These attack chips are divided into 4 categories;

- Melee which is any attack that requires the character to be in melee range of the target such as hitting them with a sword or punching
- Ranged which is any attack that use some form of direct projectile such as gunfire or lasers
- Tech which is any attack that uses some form of deployable such as grenades and turrets
- Force which is any attack that involves displacing the target or can displace the target such as throwing or knockback.

These attack categories are not mutually exclusive, for example a shotgun blast can be tagged as Ranged and Force, since it is a direct projectile that can knockback.

Bug and Hot-fix chips are used by characters to influence the effectiveness of other characters. When a bug chip is engaged, it will instead impair the opponents combat capabilities. The effect depends on the chip played and the stability of the target.

Bug chips can apply 4 different effects;

- Damage Down which reduces the total damage the target can deal,
- Movement Down which reduces the total distance the target can move.
- Stability Down which increases the total damage the target will receive and affects their susceptibility to bugs and hot-fixes.
- Downgrade which is a combination of all 3 mentioned above for the ultimate debuff

There are also a few attack chips that apply a bug, such as mace attack that also crushes the target's armour. Strategic use of these bug chips can turn the tide of any battle.

With Downgrade being the strongest of the 4 bugs it can only be applied using special chips, consumables or with the CA.

Hot-fixes can apply 4 different effects, opposite to the bug chips such as;

- Damage Up which increase the total damage the target will deal
- Movement Up which increases the total distance the target can move
- Stability Up which decreases the total damage the target will receive and affects their susceptibility to bugs and hot-fixes.
- Upgrade which is a combination of all 3 mentioned above for the ultimate buff in performance

However, unlike bug chips, you can instead find patch chips that apply these, such as an armour repair that restores HP and provides Stability Up.

With Upgrade being the strongest of the 4 hot-fixes it can only be applied using special chips, consumables or with the CA.

Decks (Chipsets)

Creating chipsets is the core to player customization. Custom chipsets will allow the player to tailor each character to fit a certain playstyle.

The PC (Player Character) is the one with the greatest amount of flexibility, having access to a wide range of chips to perform a wide range of actions. Creating an effective chipset is the key and either by focusing on flexibility so that they can synergise with party members or be the core the team works around are ideal ways to take advantage of the players expanded chip selection.

The other characters at the player's disposal will have a more limited pool of chips due to their character profile but will still provide enough flexibility to not be lumped into a single role. These characters have unique chips that are not shared with other party members with a chance for the PC to acquire a copy upon meeting certain requirements.

These chipsets are modified and saved at the service NPC for a small fee and are central to the overall gameplay loop, allowing the player to adapt to new challenges that arise.

Party Management

The player will be able to interact with a variety of characters which they can enlist into their party, these will mostly comprise their team of operatives but as they progress through the game they will unlock additional characters.

Each party member will have a role to fulfil and have their own chipset which can be customised with their own list of chips they can use and unlock separate of the player character.

The player will be able to pick a handful of characters to synergize with their own build or prefer to bring characters they enjoy and use themselves to fill in the gaps, allowing the player greater flexibility in how they handle tactical challenges.

Combat Resource Management

When engaged in combat, Characters will have 2 resources to manage; Hit Points (HP) and Action Points (AP).

HP is an indicator of a character's durability. It is displayed with both their current HP and their max HP. All characters have their own HP pool that is determined by Level and Stats.

Upon reaching 0 HP a character is defeated and becomes knocked down. It is possible to restore HP using Healing Cards (Patching) and can also be restored from the knocked down state (Resetting).

AP is an indicator of a character's ability to take action in a single turn. It's displayed with a current and max AP. Most characters will start combat with 3 AP on their turn and gain an additional 3 AP per turn up to the max amount of 5 AP.

Any AP not used in a turn will carry over but cannot exceed the characters max amount. Characters can have a higher or lower starting AP, AP per Turn and/or max AP based on stats and equipment.

AP is used by characters to perform various actions. These actions are Attacking another character, performing movement/specialised traversal, assisting team members by providing buffs (Hot-Fixing) or Patching them, Hot-Fixing or Patching themselves or hindering enemies by debuffing (Bugging).

This is to create a dynamic where the player needs to balance action and inaction. By spending AP they can deal damage, recover and manipulate

characters but they may not be able to activate higher cost chips and combos if they commit all their AP. Ideally the player will be inclined to spend most of their AP but may find themselves only spending 1-2 AP so that they can start the next turn with 4-5 AP for combos and powerful chips.

Levels & Stats

Every character that can engage in combat has a level and a character sheet that contains their stats.

A character's level is the base indicator of challenge/strength. It's the primary factor that affects Max HP, Resistances/Defences and chip strength.

Player controlled characters will gain levels by acquiring Experience Points (EXP) from defeating enemies and completing objectives. AI controlled characters will either have a fixed level or scale based on the average level of the player party.

A character's stats are determined by their level. The stats are;

- Stability which affects Max HP, Resistances, Defences and Effect Durations,
- Tinkering which affects patching, hot-fixing and bugging chips.
- Aptitude which affects ranged and tech chips
- Mobility which affects movement distance, turn initiative and AP (Starting, Generated and Max),
- Power which affects melee and force chips,

These stats are between 1 - 100, with 100 being the max.

AI characters and party members will have fixed stats based on level. How these 2 groups differ is that AI character stats are based on archetype (form) where party members are curated based on their intended role.

The player has the chance to assign skill points upon levelling to curate the player character into a build or playstyle of their choice. There will be options to allow the player to respec if they find that their current build is lacking or discover other aspects that would like to shift into.

To make sure the player doesn't feel the need to constantly change characters or be bottle-necked, all exp is applied to everyone one on the roster, so even reserve members will still level up, allowing the player to freely change when they feel like it or it will provide a tactical edge without worrying about their levels.

Tactical Layer

The tactical layer refers to the UI that appears once combat is initiated.

The overlay for the tactical layer contains information on turn order, the current characters available AP, loaded chips/movement distance (if player controlled) and party status (HP level, stocked AP). The HP level of a character will also be displayed above them.

When attempting to activate a chip, the tactical layer will also reveal if a character is in range (based on movement distance), damage dealt/HP restored and the shortest route if possible. It will also reveal what party members are in range for tag-in combos if possible.

The tactical layer will also highlight the direction of all other characters based on where the camera is to assist the player with locating characters.

Combat

When combat starts, each character will be assigned a place in the initiative order which is influenced by their agility stat and equipment which is displayed on the tactical layer.

On a character's turn, they can choose to engage movement, attack/bug an enemy or patch/hot-fix an ally. Each of these actions incur an AP cost as indicated on the chip they wish to use.

When a character chooses to engage movement, they have access to their full movement distance to use freely during the turn. They can spend 1 AP to dash, doubling their movement or they can spend 2 AP to activate specialised traversal (Flying, teleporting, etc)

Specialised traversals are special chips which are selected (installed) when editing chipsets in the main hub. They are always available and grant extra distance or other benefits such as elevation or circumnavigating chips and effects.. They can also be used outside of combat to assist in exploration.

Another action characters can take during their turn is to interact with an opposing character. If they choose to do so, they will be able to initiate 2 different types of chips, attack chips (melee, ranged, tech and force) or bug chips.

Alternatively characters can choose to interact with allied characters which allows them to engage 2 different types of chips; Patches which restore the HP of and reset allied characters or hot-fixes which restore or improve the target's combat effectiveness.

How stability affects the duration of bugs is that it scales the duration based on the targeted characters' stability contested by the targeting characters' tinkering.

The base duration of a bug chip or effect is 3 turns. If the stability is higher than the tinkering then the duration of bugs are reduced. If the tinkering is higher than the stability then the duration of bugs are increased.

Every 20 point difference will add or remove a turn from the duration, for example, a 80 stability against a 100 tinkering will affect a bugs duration by adding a turn. Opposite to that, 100 stability against a 80 tinkering will affect a bugs duration by removing a turn.

For a hot-fix the base duration is 2 turns, Tinkering will scale the base duration of the effect which is then further scaled by stability of the target.

For every 25 points of tinkering it will add 1 turn to the duration of the hot-fix. This can then be further increased by the target's stability with every 30 points adding another turn. This means that if the player has 1 character max out tinkering and another with 90 stability a hot-fix could last for 9 turns.

Combos

Certain chips can be played in order to trigger a combo, which provides an increased damage output and activates the CA system to create a cinematic attack. Combos can also be triggered with nearby allies if they have an appropriate combo card.

Combo chips are attack chips marked with either initiator, continuer or finale. Most of these chips can also be played standalone but gain increased damage or secondary effects if played in a combo. Combo states are a secondary tag displayed on the chip as it's not necessary to play a combo to play the chip.

Initiators are chips that can begin a combo sequence which can be followed up with any continuer or finale card playable by that character or any nearby allied character. If they attempt to play a second initiator,

first will be treated as a standard attack and not part of a combo. These attacks are typically weak on their own but will apply a moderate strength bug on combo for the follow up attacks to take advantage of.

Continuers are chips that can be played following an initiator. They can be played as many in a row as the character has AP to spend. The intent is for continuers to be main hits in a combo where the initiator is the set up and the finale is the ending. These chips typically have increased damage or apply weaker bugs as a side effect.

Finales are special chips that can only be played on the back of a combo, trading playability for strength. These are the hardest hitting attacks in the game and are designed for a grandiose finish when used with the CA system. Playing a finale will close the combo and cause the attack to initiate but will not end the character's turn if they have either AP left to spend or movement available.

When a combo is triggered the CA activates to create a cinematic attack that allows the player to enjoy the spectacle of the attack chips they played and may even make the player try different combo chips to see what combinations they can discover. Each combo chip will have a modular attack cinematic so that the different combo sequences can blend together and create full sequences on the fly.

Combo synergy between party members is a useful tool that will allow players to dispatch opponents quickly and efficiently by giving flexibility to the combo system by allowing different party members to substitute chips in the event the current character lucks out.

Effects

Some chips will have a secondary passive effect, these include Echoing, Safeguard, Overwatch and Injection.

Echoing causes the damage and/or effect to repeat again and when played in a combo will apply to all chips in the combo. This effect can stack, so

each instance of echoing played in a combo will repeat the effect and/or the entire combo 1 time i.e. 2 instances of echoing will repeat twice for 3 instances in total. It will not trigger the CA system multiple times but instead all instances of echoing will apply at the same time when a chip activates in a combo.

The safeguard tag provides a bonus beneficial effect that is applied to an allied character that activates should the character be targeted by a hostile character's attack. They are a pre-emptive form of mitigation for when an enemy has a hard hitting attack ready or when the player wants to minimise incoming damage on a character. These effects include blocking an attack/bug, reducing the damage of an attack and preventing reduction of shield strength.

Chips flagged with Overwatch will provide additional effects that once applied to an allied character will be triggered upon enemy action. Actions that trigger these effects are moving, attacking and applying any hot-fix/bug. These effects include dealing damage, applying bugs and or patching after damage dealt.

Interjections is similar to overwatch but instead of it activating after an action, Interjections can be played to interrupt or interfere with an action. These effects include blocking a chip's use, cancelling a combo and limiting other actions.

Hub & Exploration

The nexus is the central hub that the player has access to. While in the nexus the player can access shops, services and prepare for their next trip out into the cut-throat corporate world.

The player can enter their hideout to preview missions which displays the missions objectives, enemy types and levels as well as additional information such as side mission objectives or other modifiers. The player can also edit character equipment for themselves and party

members, both nominated and in reserve, as well as double check chipsets.

The exploration is broken down into a handful of different corporate towers that each have their own unique enemy style with different strengths and weaknesses. These towers will be broken up into clusters of floors with different objectives and puzzles.

Once the player completes a cluster of floors they will have the option to return to the nexus or continue climbing the current tower. At the end of each cluster is a boss-type enemy and at the top of each tower will be a super-boss which will be unique combat encounters where the player will have control of the full roster of characters in combat. This is to make the final boss of each tower feel unique and powerful while giving the player a chance to create some moments of genuine awesomeness.

Once a player starts exploring a tower they will not be locked to that tower, so once they complete a cluster, they will be able to tackle a cluster in a different tower if they so wish. They may even be inclined to as each tower will provide unique rewards, which includes equipment and chips. So alternating towers could provide them with more tools to tackle tough challenges.

Economy & Shops

Upon defeating enemies, completing missions and tower clusters the player will be provided a sum of credits which is used to purchase various goods and use certain services. They will have access to a variety of shops and a special NPC that provides services that will allow them to augment their gameplay.

The shops are split between 3 different shops/vendors; The convenience store, the equipment store and the mysterious merchant.

At the convenience store the player will be able to purchase 1-use tools that can be used to provide an edge or turn a battle. These tools include

consumable patches, hot-fixes, bugs as well as other utility tools. The player will only be able to purchase a limited amount of these tools to encourage a balanced approach to them, using them when they'll create impact but not overly relying on them.

The equipment store is where the player can acquire some new pieces of gear to help their characters maintain an edge in combat. These pieces will include things like weapon cores, shield cores and auxiliary cores. Gear can provide either buff stats or provide other utility, like hot-fixing on combat start.

A mysterious merchant will also reside near the player hideout that they can purchase chips from, ranging from additional generic use chips to more advanced special chips that will become available as they progress through the game. The player is expected to visit the merchant often to browse the available selection between missions to keep their chipsets competitive.

The services provided are tuning, which is applying stat points and level ups, and customization, which allows the player to edit and customise character chipsets to create effective team synergy which is the key and core to succeeding in combat. These services will be provided by the same NPC and likely to be accessed between missions.

Equipment

Equipment is an important part to player customization. The influence equipment can have on a character's combat effectiveness can range from small passive buffs to more directly increasing character output.

Equipment is broken up into 3 pieces; Weapon Core, Shield Core and Auxiliary Core. These pieces provide different bonuses based on type with different stats among each type.

Weapon Cores are the base weapon that affects the base numbers of chips and is transformed based on chips played. This makes the Weapon core more important than base stats and allows the player to have a more flexible stat allocation without severely punishing their chips.

Attack chips will be calculated as a percentage of the weapon cores listed attack rating, which can be revealed by inspecting the chip, which is then further enhanced by the chip's relevant stat.

Each weapon core will also provide small bonuses to specific chip types and can provide other small hot-fixes such as extra AP on kill or bonus initiative.

The Shield core is the primary means of mitigating damage received. While a shield core is charged it will reduce the amount of damage the character receives from an attack by a percentage indicated on the core. Stronger shield cores will provide longer coverage of defences with higher charges or will sacrifice some charges for a larger reduction on damage received.

When an attack is mitigated, it will drain 1 charge from the shield core per attack. Attacks will always drain only 1 charge regardless of the total amount of damage dealt by the attack. Charges will regenerate outside of combat back to full and can also be partially restored during combat with certain patch effects.

Shield Cores can also provide a bonus to defences and/or resistances, this provides passive utility even once the core's charges are depleted and no longer providing its damage reduction.

Just like weapon cores, shield cores can have minor hot-fixes applied that provide a bonus during combat such as increased defence against resisted attacks, restoring a small amount of HP upon receiving damage or a chance to restore a charge.

The final piece of equipment is the auxiliary core. These are used to directly influence stats on a character. They will be primarily used to compensate for lesser stats or to double down on the primary stats for each character. This is to add an extra layer of flexibility on top of the weapon cores and shield cores so that each character can be tailor made to a play style that fits the players intent. Unlike the other 2 pieces of gear, they will not provide any minor hot-fixes in favour of providing a more substantial passive boost to character stats.

Moment To Moment Gameplay

Gameplay Modes

The game will contain just the 1 game mode;

- Campaign: The campaign is the story mode that will allow the player to explore the world as well as learn and engage in the stories of the characters in it. This is the main gameplay mode allowing the player to explore, fight, level and create various builds to overcome various challenges.

Avatar Actions & Abilities

The avatar actions include in the moment to moment gameplay are;

- Movement: The player will be able to explore the world to complete tasks as well as to manipulate characters in combat
- Interact: the player will be able to interact with various objects and NPCs in the game world
- Engage: The player can engage with various enemies to trigger combat
- Activate Chips: they can activate various chips to complete various tasks and actions.
- Use Items: The player can use different items to restore HP, apply hot-fixes and other various effects.
- Change Equipment: The player will be able to change out equipment for themselves and their party members as long as they are not in combat.

Main HUD Control Scheme

Outside of combat the player will have access to menus that allow them to check/change the gear of their party, check the current area map, check stats of the party as well as view and use items they have obtained.

Once in combat the HUD will change to show a character's current loaded chips, the initiative order, available AP, character locations, movement distance, the current HP/Shield Charges of all characters on the field and prompts to complete a turn and commit actions.

Enemies & Obstacles

The player will face a variety of enemies.

Interactive Environmental Elements

The player will be able to interact with terminals, doors, platforms and other moveable objects.

Multiplayer

There is no planned multiplayer

Achievements

No achievements have been considered at this time

Level Design

The Nexus:

The layout of the nexus will be a Y intersection with the convenience store in the fork of the road with the hideout and services on the right side with the equipment store on the left side with the mysterious merchant in an alleyway next to it.

Nexus Concept Layout

The Hideout:

The hideout is broken up into 4 areas. These areas are the planning table, where the player can preview tower clusters, check mission objectives and other modifiers, a prep area where they can check and adjust gear for all party members, a social area where the player can interact with party members and potentially unlock additional missions and rewards and a communications hub where they can obtain optional missions and check current chipsets and all unlocked chips.

Hideout Concept Layout

Cluster Floors:

There will be different types of cluster floors which will vary based on the floor objective and the tower the cluster belongs to. They will vary from cubicle spaces, open factory floors, warehouses and other spaces.

Various Floor Concept Layout

Audio

Game Shell

Testable Shell

The testable shell is simply the minimum needed to be able to see if a test is feasible.

The testable shell will likely need only;

- ❖ Basic movement
- ❖ Turn based system
- ❖ Chip system

Minimum Viable Product

The Minimum Viable Product is the minimum needed to see if there can be an enjoyable gameplay loop. (should not require complex code or anything beyond greyblocks)

The minimum Viable Product will need.

- ❖ Basic movement
- ❖ Turn based system
- ❖ Chip system
- ❖ Combo system
- ❖ AP system
- ❖ HP/Shield
- ❖ CA system

Information & Options

The options that the player will be able to adjust are;

- Sound: the player will be able to adjust the audio levels of various types of sounds such as SFX, music, dialogue and ambient.
- Graphics Quality: the player will be able to adjust various graphics settings to optimise performance of the game based on their system specifications.
- Accessibility: the player can enable various accessibility options such as subtitles, colorblind assistance and other settings.
- Keybinds: the player will be able to view and edit keybinds to customise how they interact with the game.

Tutorial & Help System

The player will be introduced to the game systems through a guided experience. Different aspects of the game will be explained through a combination of prompts and gameplay.

The prompts are the text based explanation of the different mechanics and how they function. They will mention what they do, how to engage with them and what other systems they interact with.

Alongside the prompts, they will be taught how to use mechanics through gameplay where applicable. An example of this is the tutorial of activating chips where the prompt will highlight the different elements listed on the chip such as the AP cost, numbers, effects, tags and how they work while giving them an opportunity to use the chips immediately so they can understand how it works in gameplay.

Typical Player Experience Sequence

In the nexus the player will prepare for their next mission by acquiring more consumables from the store before visiting the equipment store to view available gear and potentially purchase better gear. After that they will visit the merchant to check for new chips before visiting the services vendor to preview and update any chipsets if they acquired any new chips.

They would then enter their hideout and visit the prep area to equip any new gear they have obtained and talk to their party members. They would then check the communications hub to check for new missions before using the planning table to prepare their next incursion.

Once the player has picked a floor cluster, they would then be able to freely move around looking for loose loot, opportunities, complete objectives and engage in combat against enemies.

Once the player loads into combat, it will load a combat arena that matches the design of the floor they are on. Once the initiative order has been determined, it will alternate between the player characters and the enemies, allowing them to perform a variety of actions.

If the player is victorious a display will appear revealing all rewards for the encounter. If the player is defeated they will be given the chance to try the fight again, restart the current floor or return to the nexus.

This will loop across a total of 5 floors per cluster, with the final floor containing some form of boss fight. Upon defeating the boss the cluster will be flagged as completed, unlocking the next cluster in the chain and providing the player a chance to continue immediately or return to the nexus.

Glossary

Chips: Playing cards that are used by characters to perform actions.

Chipsets: Decks that contain a selection of cards.

Bugs: A debuff that is applied to characters.

Debuff: to decrease a characters' attributes or abilities with a spell, skill, or item.

Hot-fix: a buff that is applied to characters.

Buff: make (an element in a role-playing or video game) more powerful

TRPG: Tactical Role-Playing Game

CA: Cinematic Action

HUD: Heads Up Display

AP: Action Points

HP: Hit Points

EXP: Experience Points

Patching: Healing another character